Empathy Map

Phase 1: Brainstorming & Ideation

1. Target User

The initial target user is a traveller who wants a first plan for a trip without spending hours collecting and arranging information: a student, a couple, a family or a small group organizer. This is a design persona for the project, not a claim that a formal interview study was carried out.

2. What the User Says

Typical statements would be: "We have 3,200 dollars and four days; what should we do?", "I do not eat meat, so please keep that in mind", "This day is too busy, can I change it?", and "I want a printed copy for the trip." These are likely needs used to guide the interface and should be validated with real users.

3. What the User Thinks

The user may wonder whether the plan fits the dates, whether the total cost stays inside the budget, whether the daily pace is comfortable, and whether the suggestions suit the group. These concerns are why the app shows a budget summary and lets the user edit activities, and why costs are labelled as estimates.

4. What the User Does

The user opens the site, signs in (or uses the one-click demo sign-in), starts a new plan, and moves through the five wizard steps: destination and dates, travellers and budget, style and interests, dietary and accessibility needs, and a final review. After generation the user reads the day-wise plan, edits or regenerates days, saves the trip, and prints it.

5. What the User Feels

The user may feel overwhelmed by many sources and uncertain about how to distribute activities across days, and relieved when an organized first draft appears. A guided wizard, a clear progress indicator and a loading state during generation are meant to keep the experience calm.

6. Pain Points and Desired Gains

- Pain: trip information is spread across pages. Gain: one wizard collects the core preferences.
- Pain: an attraction list is not a schedule. Gain: a day-wise plan with morning, afternoon and evening slots.
- Pain: cost overruns appear too late. Gain: a live budget summary with an over-budget warning.
- Pain: a generated plan cannot be adjusted. Gain: inline editing, deletion and day regeneration.
- Pain: plans get lost. Gain: Saved Trips with search and style filter.
- Pain: dietary and mobility needs are overlooked. Gain: dedicated wizard fields that are passed to the AI prompt.

7. Design Implications

The interface uses clear labels, a stepper that shows progress, understandable validation messages, and a loading indicator while the plan is generated. Costs are shown as estimates, and the printable view removes navigation and buttons. This empathy map is a working design hypothesis, not evidence of completed interviews.